XOXO

By Craig Shafer

Randy – mid to late 20s. Laid back and in control of his emotions; charming, but rarely cocky.

RANDY: (Pgs 33-41) *(unfolds a newspaper and scans with his finger; finds the item of interest, and begins reading)* On December 23rd, Randy Crawford was the victim of a tragic automobile accident. He lost control of his vehicle on the icy roads of Wolf Creek Pass. He was transported to St. Mark's Medical Center where he never regained consciousness. Mr. Crawford is survived by Julia, his loving wife and his daughter Hailey, six. . . *(his voice trails off; he clears his throat, sets the paper down and speaks to the audience)*

I don't know about you, but I was never a real fan of obituaries. They're downright morbid, if you ask me. It creeps me out to think about those people who read them every morning. (chipper mocking tone as he mimics those people) "Nothing like starting my day with a glass of fresh OJ and today's obituaries! I can't wait to find out if someone I know has gone on to the other side!

But that one, that one I had my own morbid curiosity about. Probably because it was mine.

INTRODUCTION

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RANDY: Wait, lemme guess. You have a whole bunch of questions for me. Save your breath, lemme see if I can cover all of them. *(beat)* I'm here . . . but what I don't know is ***why***. It's like being in a big, clear bubble. I can see everything that's going on around me, but I'm not part of it. The living world is a giant stage play, and I'm the one-person audience that can't boo or cheer. Don't ask me to explain. There wasn't any instruction manual. If they passed out The Dummies Guide to Being Dead and

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Perpetually in Limbo, I guess I missed it. *(looks down for a moment, collecting his thoughts)*

Oddly enough, I haven't thought about having a drink for a while now. And that's a big step for me. That was the last thing I had before the accident. I was over at Mickey's, off Highway 80, drinking with the guys after work. I didn't have just one or two, I had a bunch. The weather was bad, the roads were icy, and I shouldn't have driven. I lost control of the car and had a close encounter with a big oak tree. That's it. That's the ugly truth.

One of the weirdest things about being dead is that it makes the truth seem a lot less scary. If I was still alive, I would be all about baffling you with BS, giving you a line, trying to justify everything I ever did. But now, I don't have to do that anymore. I can just tell it.

I was probably an alcoholic from about 17, when I'd go out and party with my boys and then come home, sneak up to my room and party with another four or eight or twelve of my friends . . . they all happened to be named Bud Light. I was always either drunk or hungover in front of my parents. And either they loved me too much or too little to notice.

I met Julia in college when I was 20. Julia was the most beautiful girl I had ever seen in my life. Julia was worth ***not*** drinking. And so I didn't. For about a year. We got married a year later and I was the happiest guy in this little universe of ours. She was all I wanted. All I needed. But then Jules got pregnant, and, well, I got scared. Really, freakin', out-of-this-universe scared. I had these nightmares where I'd forget to feed the baby, or I wouldn't hold it right and I'd accidentally drop it on its head. So, I started drinking again. Not a lot but sometimes, you know. The scariest part was actually being in the delivery room with Jules. And, I know how corny this sounds, but I realized how incredibly amazing life really was. [Hayley] was this tiny little person with bright red curls and these giant blue eyes and . . . I was a Dad. I told her something when she was

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just two days old. I told her . . . *(suddenly holding Haley in his arms, speaking to her very softly)*

"Your Dad is going to protect you forever. I'm gonna make sure you have everything you ever want or need. I love you." And I meant it. It's important that you know that. I loved Julia, but my love for Haley was a hurt-your-heart kind of love. I call her Halo, because she's a little angel. *(close to tears; clears his throat and looks back at his audience)* Alright, now you're thinking I'm some kinda touchy-feely, sappy sorta guy. Well, I'm not. I love pro wrestling and poker and lots of manly-man kind of stuff. Seriously. *(long beat)*

I tried to quit drinking. I tried even harder after Haley was born. I went to so many AA meetings that I'd show up at a work meeting and when it was my turn to talk, I'd almost blurt out, "My name is Randy and I am an Alcoholic." The meetings would work for a while and then I'd stop going. If I hadn't drank in a week or a month, I'd convince myself I didn't need to go anymore. That the meetings were stealing my time with Julia and Haley. And then I'd drink again. I went to my doctor and got some prescription . . . the pills gave me heartburn. And . . . umm . . . after a few days I still wanted a beer, so I washed one down with a Heineken. I went through hypnosis, I saw a therapist, I went to outpatient treatment. And every time, I'd stop . . . for a little while.

I never, ***ever*** hit my wife. I ***never*** yelled at my daughter. I wasn't an angry drunk. I was what the substance abuse people call a "Disorganized Alcoholic." When I was drunk, I was useless. I wouldn't do the things I'd promised to do and that's how I hurt my family. I saw the pain on Julia's face every time I'd start again. I'd drink myself into a stupor and then I'd sleep for 12, 14, 16 hours to recover. Too drunk to pick Haley up from school. Too drunk to have dinner with our friends. I was sleeping so I couldn't go with Haley to the park to feed the ducks. *(pauses, stares blankly)*

When Haley was 5, I missed her kindergarten play. "The Grinch Who Stole

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Christmas." Haley was little Cindy-Lou Who. You know, the little who-girl who tells the mean-old grinch not to steal her family's Christmas tree. I slept through it. My boss had bitten my head off at work because I hadn't finished a project on time and so I went through two six-packs as soon as I got home. I was out cold by the time the curtains went up at Haley's school. I woke up in the middle of the night and went to the kitchen for water and Tylenol, and she'd left me a note on the counter. I've saved it in my wallet ever since. *(takes the note out of his wallet and reads aloud)*

Dear Dad: Mom says I was the best Cindy-Lou ever. I'm really sad that you were not there, because you're my Dad. I want you to always be my Dad and not the Grinch. But I love you even when you're the Grinch. XOXO, Halo. *(refolds the note and returns it to his wallet)*

What kind of father hurts his little girl like that? What kind of father picks a beer over his daughter? What kind of father was I? It was the same with Julia. I wasn't the father or husband they deserved. I was sober enough to somehow hang on to a job and provide for them but drunk too much to be the man I meant to be. The man I wanted to be. It was this evil, horrible voice inside me, telling me to drink, insisting that I needed it. I could keep it quiet for a little while, but I couldn't make it go away forever. I couldn't kill it. I tried. I really tried. *(clears his throat and considers something for a moment)*

I've been honest about everything except for one thing. *(beat)* That night at Mickey's I only had a couple of beers. I went out to my little red Tercel and I said, "Alright, Ernesto, you've served me well, Buddy, but it's last call." I had to keep myself together, you know? And I drove up to that spot on Wolf Creek Pass, the bend right before the oak, the spot I'd picked out weeks before. There weren't any other cars on the road, and I just sat for a minute and thought about how much I loved Jules and Halo and how I knew what I had to do. Then I jammed my foot hard on the accelerator. I hit that big old oak tree head on. Like a fly on a windshield.

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And then I died, alone on Wolf Creek Pass in the middle of the night in my old rusty Toyota Tercel that I'd named Ernesto. *(beat)* I couldn't keep living as someone I didn't mean to be. I couldn't keep hurting the two people I loved more than I loved myself. I'd taken out a life insurance policy a few months before and set everything up to look like an accident. *(beat)* My death wasn't ruled a suicide. Everything worked out just as I *planned. (pauses again, uncertain)*

Perhaps you think I'm weak. Or you think I'm a horrible person. Well . . . I wasn't a very good one when I was alive. *(beat)* Sometimes, in life, you're given a range of options and you pick the best of the bunch. And the best I could do was make sure that they'd never need a penny. And that's what I did. Because I couldn't stop. I told Haley when she was two days old that I'd give her anything she ever needed. I was able to give more in death than I was in life. *(long beat)*

What I didn't count on was having to watch afterwards. I never even considered that. I thought it would just be black, to be honest with you. I never thought I'd watch Jules go out on her first date since I died. But I wasn't angry. I saw happiness in her eyes -- a happiness I hadn't seen for a long, long time. I didn't think I'd have to watch Haley and not be able to pick her up and hold her. I didn't think that was how it worked.

I don't know how long I have to stick around here and I sure don't know what's next. Maybe there's two options, maybe there's more. I'm almost as scared of that as I was when Halo was born. I do know one thing, though, I can wait forever. If that's the price, I can handle it. Because that's how long love can wait. It's like living as a shadow -- existing as the strange shades of grey between black and white. Not being with the living but not quite dead either. I can handle it. I'm probably not supposed to even try to communicate -- I'm sure it's against the rules or something, but I wrote something and I'm going to leave it on the kitchen counter at the house. And then I'm going to keep waiting. *(unfolds another note and reads aloud, very softly)*

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Dear Halo: Your Dad wants you to know that you did a really super job as the Great Pumpkin in your Halloween Play. You were so spooky! He also wants you to know that life is going to be really, really hard sometimes. You're going to have to be so strong. It will seem impossible. But it's not. Life is beautiful, and you will be loved by so many people. Love them, Halo, and let them love you back. Don't ever be controlled, not by anything.

Tell Mom that Dad loves her and wants her to be happy. He loves you too -- forever, and that's a real long time. Even when you can't see him, he's there watching to keep you safe. He isn't drinking and he won't ever again.

XOXO. *(refolds the note and shakes his head sadly to end selection)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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